WEEK 6 · LECTURE L1 OF 3 · UNIT II

Engagement Apps, Chatbots and Mobile HR

What these tools actually do, where they over-promise, and why GreenLeaf's frontline is hard to reach.

Part 1 Pulse and engagement apps; continuous performance management

Part 2 HR chatbots and mobile-first design

Part 3 Where the tools over-promise; the frontline reach problem

Read Bondarouk, Parry and Furtmueller (2017), adoption sections

R K Singh · Senior Professor, Department of Commerce · Delhi School of Economics, University of Delhi · DSEH001 · M.Com. PGCF 2025

PART 1 · ENGAGEMENT TOOLS

An annual survey measures; a pulse must act

Annual survey

Long, once a year, results months later. Good for trends, poor for action. GreenLeaf's paper survey drew a 41% response.

Pulse survey

A few questions, weekly or monthly, fast results. It works only if the organization visibly acts on what it hears.

Close the loop

Ask, act, then tell staff what changed because of what they said. Frequency without action breeds survey fatigue.

AT GREENLEAF

PulseEngage: 900 of 3,000 licensed users active (0.30), satisfaction 2.9, pain point "Survey fatigue; results not acted upon". The tool is fine; the loop is missing.

PART 1 · CONTINUOUS PERFORMANCE

From an annual rating to frequent conversations

	Annual appraisal	Continuous performance management
Rhythm	Once a year	Regular check-ins and real-time feedback
Focus	Judging the past	Coaching the next step
Known problems	Recency bias, halo effects, politicized ratings	Needs managers able to hold good conversations
Example	Most firms before about 2012	Deloitte and Adobe redesigns (Buckingham and Goodall, 2015)

AT GREENLEAF

Performance management runs on spreadsheets at maturity level 2, with "Ratings inconsistent across stores; no calibration data". A tool without manager skill would digitize the inconsistency.

PART 2 · HR CHATBOTS

Deflection is not resolution

Two kinds of bot

Rule-based bots follow fixed decision trees. AI bots read free text in many languages, but can answer wrongly with confidence.

The trap

Deflection counts queries a bot handled without a human. Resolution counts problems actually solved. A bot can deflect 60% and resolve far less.

The design rule

Measure resolution, and give every conversation an exit to a person.

AT GREENLEAF

SahayakBot runs on WhatsApp and is built in house, so it can be changed: 2,600 of 8,000 active (0.33), satisfaction 3.2.

PART 2 · MOBILE-FIRST DESIGN

Design for the phone first, not a shrunken desktop

Few fields, big targets

Every extra field loses users on a small screen and a slow connection.

Work offline

Tolerate patchy data; save progress; sync later.

Speak their language

Vernacular text and voice, in channels people already use, such as WhatsApp.

Device	Share of GreenLeaf staff
Smartphone only	48.0%
Laptop and smartphone	30.3%
Laptop only	14.1%
Feature phone only	7.6%

THE GAP

Feature phone users cannot use the app or the bot. For them, voice or SMS is the only route. Source: Employee_Master, Device_Access.

PART 3 · WHERE TOOLS OVER-PROMISE

Four promises, and what GreenLeaf's data show

The promise	What GreenLeaf shows
Pulse apps raise engagement	Adoption 0.30; staff say results are not acted on
Bots cut helpdesk load	Smartphone-only staff still raise 5.1 tickets a month, laptop users 2.8
Self-service for everyone	ESS App: 2,900 of 7,000 active (0.41); 7.6% have no smartphone
Wellbeing apps help staff	WellbeingPlus: 0.18 adoption, the lowest in the stack

THE PATTERN

Tools are bought for the employee who already has a laptop. The frontline majority pays the cost of the mismatch. Sources: TechStack_Inventory; Adoption_Telemetry.

Going deeper: the theory underneath engagement and performance tools

The next slides set out goal-setting theory, feedback intervention theory, the Job Demands-Resources model, and Kahn on engagement: what each claims, how it works, where it breaks, and what it means at GreenLeaf.

THEORY IN DEPTH · LOCKE AND LATHAM (1990, 2002)

Specific, hard goals with feedback raise performance

THE CORE IDEA

Specific, challenging goals produce higher performance than vague or easy ones.

HOW IT WORKS

Goals direct attention, energize effort, raise persistence and prompt new strategies. Commitment and feedback moderate the effect.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

For complex, new tasks, learning goals work better than tough performance targets.

AT GREENLEAF

A goal app helps only if store goals are specific and feedback reaches the associate, not only the manager.

THEORY IN DEPTH · KLUGER AND DENISI (1996)

Feedback can make performance worse

THE CORE IDEA

A meta-analysis of 131 studies found that in about one third of cases, feedback reduced performance.

HOW IT WORKS

Feedback aimed at the self (rankings, judgments of the person) diverts attention from the task; task-focused feedback helps.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Effects vary widely with how, when and by whom feedback is given.

AT GREENLEAF

A leaderboard that ranks stores may lower performance. Specific feedback on the task is the safer design.

THEORY IN DEPTH · BAKKER AND DEMEROUTI (2007)

Demands drain; resources engage

THE CORE IDEA

The Job Demands-Resources model: every job has demands that cost energy and resources that build it.

HOW IT WORKS

High demands lead through strain to burnout. Resources such as autonomy, support and feedback lead to engagement.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Broad and flexible, so critics say almost anything can be called a demand or a resource.

AT GREENLEAF

An app that adds logins and forms is a new demand. It must also add a resource, such as faster leave approval.

THEORY IN DEPTH · KAHN (1990)

People engage when work is meaningful, safe and possible

THE CORE IDEA

Engagement is bringing your whole self to the role: physically, mentally and emotionally.

HOW IT WORKS

Three conditions: meaningfulness (it matters), psychological safety (it is safe to speak), availability (I have the energy and means).

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

A qualitative study of two settings; later survey measures stretched the original idea.

AT GREENLEAF

A pulse survey where staff fear their answers will be traced fails the safety condition before any question is asked.

TAKEAWAYS

Three things to carry out of this lecture

1

A pulse tool works only when results are acted on and reported back.

2

Measure chatbot resolution, never deflection alone.

3

Design for the phone and the regional language first.

NEXT Integration and adoption: why good tools still fail.